Reflection

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38470081.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Summary

Becoming She-ra is so different for Adora. She doesnt know how she is supposed to adjust to this new form when the person most capable of helping her through it hates her guts now. She has a world to save though, so she is forced to push forward as the gap between her and Catra grows ever wider. At least She-ra's unusual form provides some solace as she adjusts to life without her best friend.
(Or, the magicat She-ra fic)

Enemies

Chapter Notes

> My friend Jem asked for prompts on a drawing stream and malachai-walker suggested magicat She-ra, which made this dumb AU sprung into my head. The drawing (it's currently my desktop). She is based off a cream/white maine coon. Chapter count is an estimate still. **Rating might change**, most likely to M if it does.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Was the mural in the entrance She-ra?" Catra asks, breaking the silence that she demanded in the first place as they wander down the corridors of the Crystal Castle. Adora pauses, glancing to the side to find Catra already scowling, her ears pinned back.

"What, didn't get a good look at it before you broke everything and set off the intruder alarm? Yeah, it's She-ra," Adora returns. She can't hold back her snark when they are stuck searching for an exit while Glimmer is depending on her. Catra scoffs, sounding annoyed at Adora when all *she* did was remind Catra that the source of all her problems right now is her own actions.

"She was human. Why do you look like *that* when you become her?" Catra asks, barbs lining her tone. Adora would wince if she wasn't used to Catra sounding like she hates her by now. She doesn't know what Catra feels about her anymore – one second she's kidnapping Adora's friends, the next she's helping them escape, it's *confusing* – but her tone is never fond when talking to Adora these days.

"I don't know. Queen Angella was only able to turn up one depiction of her as a magicat. All the other stuff seems to be a human," Adora replies, shrugging. "Growing seven feet tall would be a lot to adjust to on its own, but becoming an entirely different race has had a big adjustment curve. She could really use Catra's help figuring it out,

but Catra seems to hate She-ra with a burning passion. She already didn't want to leave the Horde with Adora, but a look of anguish and *hatred* clouded Catra's features when she saw She-ra for the first time back in Thaymor. It hasn't left since.

"How does that *work*?" Catra demands, narrowing her eyes at Adora. She isn't watching where they are walking, though there hasn't been anything exciting about this corridor so far. At least they haven't wandered into another memory made all-too-real yet.

"Magic? I just-" Adora reaches back for the sword, lifting it up above her head, and declares, "For the honor of Grayskull!" Light washes over her as Catra hisses. When the glow fades, Catra has scrambled all the way back to be against the wall of the hallway, as far away as she can be from Adora's magicat form. She glares at Adora, her gaze fiery.

"What, jealous because my tail is fluffier than yours?" Adora asks, smugly, as she settles the sword at her back again. She doesn't actually need She-ra right now, but she doesn't always have a reason for transforming. When Glimmer or Bow walks in on her just *existing* as She-ra, she justifies it as needing to be used to this new body if she is going to fight effectively in it, but sometimes she is just exploring being a magicat. The world is entirely different, her perception of it changed. Everything is softer through a layer of fur, and not in the smothering way that the beds in Bright Moon are. The giant mane and equally majestic tail help too.

"You're so conceited," is Catra's sneering response as she pushes off the wall and starts walking forward again. Adora's expression falls, but she hurries forward to follow. It isn't hard to keep pace at Catra's side with her longer legs. She has adjusted to the feeling of claws on her feet and hands by now, but she doesn't have the mastery that comes from time that Catra does. Catra glances down as Adora's claws click softly against the ground as she walks. Catra sniffs, disdain curling at her lip as she looks ahead again, her own footfalls silent.

"You're a shitty magicat," she adds, looking forward with her ears pinned back. Adora's heart twists painfully in her chest. For a moment, she struggles for a response, trailing helplessly beside Catra. Her tail is limp behind her, brushing against her legs as she walks. Normally she can't stop it lashing when she faces off with Catra, adrenaline in her blood making itself known.

"You could teach me to be better," she breathes. She has thought about it a *lot*. Every time she digs her claws into something, she thinks of when Catra would sneak into her bunk and knead on her. Her claws would hurt when they pricked Adora, but the rhythmic motion was soothing aside from that, and Catra's content purr was more than enough motivation for Adora to let her do it. She has tried kneading for herself and quickly tore the pillow she was using apart, never finding that happy rhythm that came to Catra so naturally.

None of this is natural to Adora. She doesn't know how to be a magicat. She doesn't even know *why* She-ra is a magicat. The claws and heightened senses are a definite advantage, but if She-ra isn't always a magicat, why is she one now? Adora hasn't had much of a guide. With She-ra gone for the last thousand years, there isn't anyone who knows the answer. She could use help at least understanding the new capabilities that She-ra grants her, but Catra can hardly stand her anymore. Catra sneers, her expression twisting and wringing Adora's heart out like a wet cloth with it, leaving the blood from the various injuries that they have inflicted on each other dripping helplessly over her fingers.

"Please, we both know you don't *need me* anymore," Catra bites back before taking off down the hall. Adora's breath stutters for a moment before she manages to throw herself forward and give chase.

"Catra, wait! That's not true!" she calls after her as Catra barrels down the hall and into the dark room beyond. The last thing Adora sees is her lashing tail before she disappears into shadows so thick that even Adora's magicat eyes can't pierce them. When Adora

hurtles into the room herself, she finds herself running head-long into another simulated memory of the Horde.

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Despite how exhausting the Battle of Bright Moon was, Adora can't sleep afterwards. She tosses and turns for what feels like hours before she gives up. She forces herself to stand despite the screaming ache that is settled into her bones. Her body went through a lot and she can still feel it all despite She-ra's healing factor ensuring her skin remains unbroken. She is growing used to this pain, though, and she manages not to stagger as she grabs the sword off its resting pedestal and raises it above her head.

"For the honor of Grayskull," she whispers, her voice tired and rough. It is far from the usual war cry, but magic envelopes her as a wash of warmth and *relief*. Adora draws in deep, content breaths as the pain fades away, replaced by She-ra's light. Part of the reason that Adora spends time as She-ra out of battle is because she doesn't feel the pain of her healed injuries until she drops the transformation, but the pain isn't why she transforms tonight, nor why she was sleepless.

She sets the sword on the edge of the bed, out of the way but still close enough to maintain the transformation. She slips back beneath the sheets, turning on her side to face the wall and curling up into a tight ball. One part of being a magicat she *does* have down is curling herself up tightly. She tucks her knees against her chest, sweeping her tail up to wrap around herself comfortingly. She hugs her arms around it and buries her face down into its tip, grateful for its length rivaling that of her hair.

It means in rough moments like these, she can tightly curl around her tail and pretend. Catra was never this fluffy – she and Adora have very different coat types – but it's almost like burying her face in

Catra's mane again. Fur feels different when it is her own, but this is the best she can do right now. She knows that she shouldn't pretend that she is holding Catra in order to fall asleep, but fighting her is hard, even when she does things that hurt Adora's friends. Glimmer's glitching has seemed to stop, at least.

Quietly, Adora begins purring to herself. It took her an embarrassingly long time to figure out – well, mostly embarrassing because of how hard she was trying – but it is the most soothing thing she has right now. Her body relaxes with the rumble rolling through her, the ache in her muscles nothing but a memory as she squeezes her eyes tight and pretends there is another warm body in the bed originating the rumbling sound.

It's pathetic, but with the impression of Catra in her arms, she finally falls asleep.

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Adora locks eyes with Catra in the Northern Reach and immediately feels a traitorous purr begin in her chest. She curses all the time that she spent trying to figure it out as the vibration reverberates through her chest. She thinks it is quiet enough that no one else should be able to hear it – except maybe Catra, shit – but she doesn't know how to explain this away if someone does question it. It has to just be the satisfaction at getting the drop on Catra for once.

Luckily, Catra seems too shocked by their sudden appearance to pick up on the quiet sound. As they launch themselves forward into battle, the purr vanishes and leaves only her lashing tail as evidence of her excitement. That has been present since their first battle, though, so Adora isn't worried. Fighting gets adrenaline going. It's just biology. Catra's tail often lashes when she is around Adora now too.

The speed of the battle quickly pulls her thoughts away. When the corrupted data disk appears, it all goes black.

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"I wish to test the sword. Your form is unusual. The sword should have prevented something like this from happening," Light Hope says as a receptacle raises out of a hidden tile in the floor of the Crystal Castle. Anxiety instantly pricks at Adora's heart. She pulls the sword from her back and places it carefully on the smooth purple pedestal. She came here to train with She-ra, but if she could get answers about her biggest quirk, then that is her top priority.

"She has looked like that every time I transformed. She's not supposed to?" Adora asks nervously, glancing up to Light Hope. Light Hope shakes her head stiffly, her animation flickering out for a moment as the pedestal lights up blue and the sword gently lifts up, hovering a few inches above the plate.

"The last She-ra before her runestone was affixed in the sword was a magicat, but she appeared as herself. There is no precedent for She-ra appearing as a different race than she is," Light Hope informs her. Before Adora can ask any questions, Light Hope's eyes glow and the sword slowly lowers to rest back on the pedestal again.

"Data received. It seems some of the sword's processes have degraded in the last thousand years. They are now supplemented by She-ra's magic," Light Hope informs her. Adora's heart drops as she reaches out to take the sword again, running her hand along the blade as if she will feel what is broken. She is greeted with nothing but its cold, smooth surface.

"Is She-ra okay? Are there things I should be able to do but I was too late and now She-ra's broken? She-ra got a virus before, did that

break it?" Adora asks, looking up to Light Hope desperately. Light Hope looks down at her, tilting her head slightly.

"The sword is highly advanced First Ones engineering meant to house, protect, and guide She-ra's runestone in the hilt. She-ra herself is fully functional. I am not capable of the engineering required to repair the sword and those that were perished long ago. We must continue with the sword in its current state," she lists off, clinically. Adora bites her lip, looking down at the sword. The blade glints back at her, giving none of its secrets away.

"If she never looked different before, why does she now?" Adora asks, looking back up to Light Hope. There is a long moment of silence that Adora is learning means Light Hope is either running calculations or fetching data. She has done it a few times now in the handful of training sessions that they have had.

"Unknown. The sword is meant to enforce a consistent look upon She-ra. The scenario with the highest degree of plausibility is that it with the sword damaged, the runestone is trying to emulate the last She-ra it knew before the sword was made. A scenario with a lower probability rate is that She-ra's magic is trying to fill in for the lost magicat princess," Light Hope says. Adora's heart beats quickly in her chest.

"There's a magicat princess?" she can't help but ask. Aside from Catra, she only saw one or two other magicats in the Horde, always older soldiers that she saw in passing. While they were trying to figure out She-ra's form, Adora heard a few comments from Queen Angella about how magicats are rare these days, but nothing else. She didn't know that they used to have a princess and she is a bit afraid of what could have happened to her.

"The magicat princess perished with most of the population years ago. Records of intercepted communications indicate that the Horde eradicated them so they could use their city beneath the Fright Zone as a mine for producing weapons and armor. The magicat princess did not have a runestone, but the magicats were one of the earliest

races to join the First Ones on Etheria. It is possible that She-ra's form reflects her loss," Light Hope says. She barely finishes the words before she sweeps forward, giving Adora no time to process.

"Come, you must train now that my parameters have been updated to reflect the state of the sword," she calls to Adora. Adora feels like she has more questions than she got answers, but that is how every conversation with Light Hope has gone so far. She had no idea there was a magicat *city* beneath the Fright Zone, though she knew about the mine. She never visited it – it is mostly automated and supposed to be very dangerous – but it is haunting to think about now that she knows what happened there.

Is Catra the daughter of a magicat that escaped the battle? Or worse, did the Horde take her after killing her family in the conflict? She was supposed to be an orphan just like Adora, and hearing Light Hope's story Adora doesn't doubt that part, but thinking that the Horde could be who killed her parents sends a shiver down her spine. Did a similar thing happen to Adora's own family?

The pit of Adora's stomach feels like a roiling ocean. As much as she wants to ask questions, maybe training is the best thing for her right now. Anything to stop thinking about this. Hitting something would feel good, or at least better than trying to process the pain that is in her chest. She trails behind Light Hope reluctantly.

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"You're so soft, I see why you just hang out like this," Bow says, his word muffled where he has his face buried against Adora's arm. He slumped there to catch a breath after an exhausting fight with a bot, but he is breathing normally now and still hasn't moved. Adora's ears twitch as Glimmer shuffles over and leans against her other side, sighing with quiet relief as she rests against her. She feels the need

to defend herself, but she doesn't know what she can say really. She has been She-ra for over a year now. Needing to adjust to her form isn't much of an excuse anymore. It's nothing new.

Distraction might be her best option. She-ra's biceps are far from the softest part of her. Adora sweeps her tail up, wrapping it around Bow and then draping it over their laps so Glimmer can get the end of it too. Bow squeals with delight, happily reaching down and petting over her tail just like Adora used to do with Catra. Adora doesn't know how Catra avoided playing with her own tail. She has spent plenty time as She-ra just petting herself. It's soothing.

In her ideal world, she would spend all day as a magicat, curled up with Catra. They could both purr and knead each other. Everything would be so *soft*...but this isn't an ideal world and Bow was winded from fighting one of the Horde's – one of *Catra's* – many robots that she has favored sending out instead of fighting herself ever since the portal. Still, Adora gives a gentle rumble as Bow pets over her tail. Bow gasps loudly, startling Adora. She looks down, finding Bow's expression filled with stars and Glimmer appearing slightly bewildered along with Adora.

"You can *purr*?" Bow coos to her. Adora's tail flicks once in Glimmer's lap. Purposefully now, Adora rumbles a quiet response. Her purr is whisper-quiet, but it reverberates strongly in her chest, causing Bow to squeak with delight. "That's so *cute*!" he declares, happily throwing his arms around Adora's torso in an awkward hug. Adora's tail is flicking steadily now, her ears pressing back against her head. She is getting a taste of what it was like for Catra to be on the receiving end of Adora's affection and it is surprisingly flustering, though it feels good too.

Adora likes being a magicat. It's as fun as it is comforting. She still doesn't have Catra's agility, but she can climb just about anything and her hearing becomes unparalleled. She feels more capable as a magicat, and sometimes even more comfortable. When they rough it on missions, she occasionally sleeps as She-ra. It's easier to bed down as a magicat. She finally understands why she would find

Catra all over the Fright Zone, sleeping in positions that seemed uncomfortable or even *perilous*.

"You know she purrs in her sleep, right?" Glimmer asks, looking over to Bow. Adora did not, in fact, know that she did that, but she isn't surprised. She swears purring eases the aches in her body that follow healing. The most surprising part is that Bow hasn't noticed but Glimmer, who is spending more time in Bright Moon and not even accompanying them on all their missions, did. Bow pulls back to send Glimmer an expression that Adora can only describe as *aghast*.

"She *does*?" he asks, his tone going high. He sounds distraught. Glimmer rolls her eyes, though she is notably still leaned against Adora's side and has one hand buried in the fluff of her tail.

"You probably snore so loudly you can't hear anything else," Glimmer tells him, sticking her tongue out. Bow looks betrayed as Adora snickers to herself. Bow's snoring has never bothered her – actually, she finds any background noise comforting – but Adora has a feeling that expression has nothing to do with Glimmer bringing up his snoring.

"You've known for months and you didn't tell me," he laments, throwing himself forward to hug Adora again. Adora and Glimmer exchange an amused look over Bow's head as Adora raises a hand and comfortingly pats his back. In Glimmer's defense, she thought he knew too, but Adora is happy to have any excuse to turn into She-ra and purr. She likes it just as much as Bow seems to.

Chapter End Notes

> It was a purposeful decision on the part of the First Ones to not give Light Hope the ability to repair (and thus modify) the sword. The magicat thing is my headcannon for magicats in the show. For those who don't know, there actually WAS a magicat princess at some point, as seen in the line-up of princesses that Light Hope shows Adora. My headcannon is that Catra's mask

was stolen from them as a bloody victory trophy and used to be worn by the magicat princess (I dont think Catra actually IS the magicat princess, but who knows what is going on with them). In this AU, She-ra was the goddess of Etheria long before the First Ones settled it (as is implied in the show). The first She-ras after the First Ones settled Etheria and discovered her were Eternians/humans, but once other races started coming to settle as well, the next She-ra that the runestone selected was the most worthy person at the time – a magicat. The First Ones scrambled, not wanting such a powerful resource to slip through their fingers, and so they crafted the sword to keep her trapped – both as a First One in general, but also as one under their control. They could take custody of the sword and keep her locked in the form of their "ideal soldier". The runestone remembers the last free She-ra in the line as a magicat. When the sword is broken, who knows what will happen 👀

Catra's Interlude

Chapter Notes

> Originally this fic was supposed to be entirely from Adora's perspective to stop it from being too angsty, but it's too late to make it just humor and fluff, so give me this one scene. Remember the light angst tag? Yeah, that's for everything except this scene. This is just full angst. That's your warning. This is skippable ~~if you're a coward~~.
> CW: Self hatred. I mean, it's Catra, but on a scale from 1 to 10, every negative feeling that Catra feels about She-ra in canon is turned up to about 60 in this AU.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra hates her. She hates her so much. When she sees her across the battlefield, she doesn't even see Adora anymore under the new coat of fur. She-ra might as well be a personification of everything that Catra can't be. ~~her~~ failures taunt her, wearing a shadow of her best friend's face when they fight. Every childhood injury Catra sustained for not being an obedient little soldier stings when she sees Adora succeeding at being everything that Shadow Weaver tried to force Catra to be.

She couldn't. She's not Adora. She is cursed to be herself, a miserable and wretched little thing that was snatched up in the ~~bird~~'s jaws as a baby and dragged down into its dark lair. Of course Adora was able to find her way out and walk into the light – she's *Adora*. She's practically made of sunshine. She was certainly the only bright spot in Catra's childhood, but even that seems tarnished now that Adora is able to transform and take the one advantage that Catra had over her away from her.

They were always neck-and-neck growing up. Catra thought they were real fucking friends – she thought maybe, in another life, that

they could have been *more* – but once Adora could turn into a magicat herself she didn't hesitate to walk away. She only invited Catra to join her after Catra went searching for her. She was worried about Adora, but Adora treated her as nothing more than an afterthought. All those years and stolen moments together, every one giving Catra hope and some sense of temporary peace, have added up to nothing.

It must have been meaningless to Adora, because she didn't hesitate to toss Catra aside. As far as Catra is concerned, Adora ripped out her heart and buried it in a tank-track back in Thaymor. It lies mangled in the dirt, trapping Catra in limbo. She can feel nothing but the howling rage and pain that rushed in to fill the gap it left behind. She always knew she was unlovable, but she thought maybe Adora *cared* about her at least. She was so fucking naïve. Adora gets her magic powers and she happily leaves Catra behind, bitter and broken.

Adora isn't even *good* at being a magicat, but she's Adora, so of course everyone finds what she does amazing while Shadow Weaver continues to treat Catra like shit stuck to her boot. With every desperate attempt Shadow Weaver makes to bring Adora, Catra feels more tormented. She is used to Shadow Weaver hissing *why can't you be more like Adora?* whenever she gets feisty, but never has the comparison been so obvious. Now that Adora is off playing She-ra, Catra means nothing to anybody.

The best she has is Scorpia, who is an annoyance at best. She follows Catra around, trying to get her to open up. If Catra allowed her chest to open, all the blood coagulating where her heart should be would spill out. Catra doesn't think she can get more weak and pathetic, but she knows better than to try and let someone in again. Catra was born to be discarded, it seems. All she has left is her rage and her spite, pride fueling her every action. She isn't Adora. She never can be. She doesn't know how to be good – but she will make them pay. She will show them why they never should have cast her

aside. If they wont love her , maybe one day she can at least make them sorry.

She tells herself that would be as good as love. She still cries herself to sleep sometimes, curled up in the privacy of a supply closet or some dark corner, tucked away from the world that wants to hurt her so bad. In her weakest moments, she wonders what things would have been like if Adora did love her – if she stayed with the Horde and they conquered the world together like they always planned. She cant really imagine looking at Adora' s face with those big, dumb, tufted ears framing it and not feeling hatred, but in a world where Adora never tossed her aside, she has no reason to.

She only thinks about it in her weakest moments, curled up alone and wishing there was another body there or anyone who loved her. She wonders what it would be like to spend time with "another magicat" – even if Adora is bad at replacing Catra, she looks and feels similar to her now and Catra has never gotten to spend time with someone else like her – but the moments are fleeting. The thoughts make bile rise in her throat and she almost always ends up crying when she has them.

It isnt because it evokes hatred in her . It's because it makes her long for something she will never have. While she languishes in darkness, waiting for it to consume her until she finally feels nothing, Adora moves on like its nothing. After all, she has new friends and an entire Rebellion to support her now. She lost nothing but Catra when she left the Fright Zone.

Catra is nothing to her. Adora lost nothing.

Chapter End Notes

> Yes I changed the chapter count. Now shut up about it. It still might change again.
> Sad cat.

Friends?

Chapter Notes

> As always, I consider "Dont Go" canon so it's lightly referenced.
> CW: canon/Adora-typical self-negativity and self-sacrificial view in the first scene.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sword breaks, and Adora breaks with it. Light Hope said that She-ra was older than the sword, but with her runestone still trapped in its ruined hilt, Adora can't reach her. She tries – she holds the sword aloft, breathing the passphrase and desperately hoping to give it life again, and she even tries to pry the runestone free – but nothing works. Light Hope is gone, but even if she wasn't, Horde Prime keeps them on the run and Adora has no hope of doubling back to the Crystal Castle.

There is no point. She already knows nothing there can fix the sword. She-ra is gone, along with Glimmer. The Rebellion is scrambling, and though Adora tries to give it everything that she has, she has never been enough. Even when she had She-ra, she was barely enough to keep the Horde at bay. Now their opponent is more dangerous than ever and she has nothing. She *is* nothing.

She doesn't sleep anymore. She doesn't have the time and she just *can't*. She longs for the days when she could curl up as She-ra and purr, but instead she works through the night as often as she can. The Rebellion needs her. She has to make up for the gap left by She-ra's absence. She has to do *something*. Her power is gone, her weapon is gone, even her comfort is gone, but this isn't about her. She is meant to protect Etheria and it has never been under more threat.

When she does try to sleep – usually after being forced to by her friends – she lies on her back and feels hollow. The familiar and

once-comfortable cot feels like a rock. All softness is gone from her world. Quietly, she wishes for the plush beds of Bright Moon that she didn't appreciate when she had them. It feels more appropriate to yearn for them than for the comfort of soft fur, whether her own or someone else's. Catra hasn't been sighted since Prime appeared, though, and it isn't like she and Adora were in any place for affection anyway.

Everything just hurts. Adora has felt alone at many points throughout the war, especially over the last few months, but she always was able to get some sense of comfort from turning into She-ra. She opens her eyes, staring across at where the sword rests in her tent. It doesn't even shine in the sliver of moonlight that spills through the gap in the tent flaps. It remains as lifeless and broken as Adora feels. As Adora gazes at it, she wonders: Will she ever be whole again?

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In the moment, Adora's pounding emotions guide her. She isn't thinking. She is sorrow, she is rage, and she is the overwhelming instinct to protect Catra. She-ra cuts a path through the clones until she reaches the ship, her only concern getting Catra to safety. She doesn't know how she heals the ship, but in the moment she just knows that she can and that they have to get out of there.

When she cradles Catra against her chest and wills life into her, she sees her own hands, but they don't matter. It isn't until after Catra is healed and resting that it really catches up with Adora. As she sits on the floor of the main deck, Glimmer sidles up to her and sits by her side, quickly flopping over to lean against her. Adora wraps an arm around her, squeezing her in a sideways hug. It's nice to have her back. Adora didn't get to really enjoy it before when she was so worried about Catra.

“So. She-ra’s human now?” Glimmer asks around a yawn. She sounds exhausted. The rescue definitely didn’t go to plan, but it was a success in the end. The broken look in Catra’s eyes as she mistook Adora for a cruel-intentioned hallucination will haunt her for the rest of her life, but they got her away from Prime at least. With She-ra now within reach again, Adora will do everything in her power to keep Catra safe, even if Catra doesn’t want her to.

“I guess. Light Hope did think it was just a glitch in the sword,” Adora answers, giving a half shrug before realizing it will disturb Glimmer and aborting the motion. Adora is grateful that Entrapta is somewhere in the bowels of the ship checking for damage because she is sure that she would have dozens of questions and Adora has none of the answers.

She glances down at her hands, turning her palms up and flexing them like the sword will magically appear in them again. Even the blade looked different. Then again, the old one was apparently just a piece of faulty tech. Maybe it was the high emotions of the moment, but Adora has never felt more powerful as She-ra. She can’t deny that she is kind of sad to find that the magicat form really was just a glitch, but it is such a relief to have She-ra back, she doesn’t care what form she takes. All that matters is that they have a fighting chance against Prime.

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Adora reaches out, her concentration and the shape of a sword flickering between her fingers. For a half second, she swears she sees claws flash over her hand, but then Catra walks in the room and any hope of pulling She-ra from the ether slips away. It had to be wishful thinking anyway. She-ra is human now.

Later, when they are almost within range of picking up a signal from Etheria, Adora finds herself alone with Catra. Adora wanders into the "pantry" hoping to find some acceptable rations and finds Catra already there, scaled up the boxes and poking around at the back of the shelves. Catra freezes, her ears and tail twitching as she slowly turns her head to see who has caught her. Adora offers her a hopeful smile and after a moment Catra unfreezes, jumping back down to the ground and crossing her arms. She slouches and looks away with a visible scowl, clearly trying to seem unphased.

"Everything here sucks. Didn't think to pack *food*?" she asks, not quite all the way to the cutting tone that became her default for awhile, but she was more lighthearted this morning. She isn't quite snapping at least. Catra has been *trying* since finally emerging from her room, but sometimes she reverts. Food was always a touchy subject for them as kids – if Shadow Weaver decided that Catra fucked up really bad, she might withhold it as punishment, though Adora never knew anyone else that she did that to – so it isn't surprising that catching Catra in the pantry sets her on edge even if Adora was often the one who helped sneak her additional food.

"We were already on the run and in a hurry. We had to make do," Adora shrugs, stepping all the way through the door so it slides shut behind her. Catra's ears twitch at the sound of it sealing and she finally looks up to make eye contact with Adora, the tension in her shoulders easing a little. "I can help you read the labels in First Ones' language if you want," she offers, glancing at the older rations. For a moment Catra is still, and then her tail swings behind her. Adora should be better at decoding Catra's moods after having a tail herself, but whenever she saw Catra hers would just be lashing.

"I'll figure it out. Is reading shit another one of your weird superpowers?" Catra returns, though her tone is significantly less cutting now. If anything, she mumbles the first part. Adora is pretty sure that Catra has seen her do it, but she is just relieved that Catra is being marginally less defensive, so she nods.

"I don't know if that is a She-ra thing or a me-thing to be honest. I'm a First One, it turns out. Maybe I could always read it and just never saw it before," Adora tells her , shrugging. She assumed it was because of She-ra at first, but she has other suspicions now, especially knowing She-ra isn't inherently a First One – that was a shackle added by the old sword. Catra snorts, uncrossing her arms and eyeing Adora for a long moment. It seems Adora being an alien is a lot less of a revelation for her than it was Adora.

"Well that explains your whole '*special*' thing. What happened to She-ra anyway? She looks like you now ," Catra asks. Adora would argue that She-ra always looked like her – at least, as much as she could given the circumstances – but she knows what Catra means. Besides, it is true in more ways than one. Almost every aspect of She-ra has changed to fit her better. She even has her ponytail now. Adora reaches up, self-consciously patting the top of her hair to make sure it is in place.

"I broke the sword to stop the heart from going off and tearing Etheria apart. I lost She-ra for weeks, but she existed before the sword was even made. I didn't know that she would look different when I managed to reach her again, but we always thought that the magicat form was a glitch in the old sword, so I guess it makes sense," Adora tells her , shrugging as she drops her hand. Catra raises a brow at her, but that's about the only response she gives Adora.

"It's kind of sad. I always wanted you to teach me how to be a magicat. And I really wanted us to both hang out as magicats," Adora tells her. Catra flushes, her ears pinning back and tail lashing as she quickly looks away . She coughs, but Adora is pretty sure that she is just giving herself an excuse to raise her hand up to her face. Covering her mouth does nothing to hide her blush, though. After a minute of forced coughing, Catra drops her hand and looks off towards the corner of the room.

"I thought about it too, sometimes," she mutters, the words coming like pulling teeth. Adora can't stop herself gasping from excitement.

Catra's gaze snaps to her immediately. She glares at her, pulling her lip back to reveal her fangs, but it isn't a true snarl. It is definitely supposed to be a threat still, even if it does nothing to deter Adora. Catra's tail lashes as she tries to glare her into silence. Adora presses her lips together, but she's having difficulty containing her smile. Catra *thought about it*.

"There were just never other magicats around! Shut up. You're insufferable," Catra tells her, stepping close enough to shove at her shoulder. Adora is grinning at she stumbles a half step back. The shove isn't strong enough to send her any further. It's Catra being Catra. Adora doesn't expect this part of her to change and she doesn't want it to. She is just happy knowing that she wasn't alone in her thoughts of the two of them getting to be together as magicats.

She-ra's new form may be more comfortable for Adora, but for the first time she *really* misses the old glitch in the sword.

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They kiss beneath the heart, and though Adora feels them lifting up as She-ra's transformation overtakes her and she draws the energy of the heart, she isn't expecting what she sees when they pull apart. The heart is dull and lifeless above them and the light is dim, but Adora's eyes see clearly in the darkness regardless as she blinks down at Catra in her arms. Catra stares up at her, wide-eyed, and then squeaks. Her tail lashes behind her as Adora's own sways hopefully.

"You're a magicat again," Catra says, a bit obviously. She sounds as breathless as Adora feels. Adora glances down at the stripes on her arms and her clawed hands holding Catra close. She looks back up to make eye contact with Catra again, offering her a smile. Her tail is still swaying behind her. In the depths of her chest, she feels the

rumble of a purr. Catra's eyes grow even wider as it becomes audible. She draws in a surprised gasp.

"Yeah. I love you," Adora replies. That's the only explanation she has. Every time she has transformed since breaking the sword, She-ra has been human. A glance down tells her that she is still in her new form, but this time she wears the uniform as a magicat. Catra flushes, her cheeks darkening as she lets out a high-pitched trill and headbutts forward, burying her face in Adora's pecs with her tail lashing behind her.

"That doesn't make *sense*," she whines. They still have a world to save above ground, but Adora takes a moment to grin and squeeze her close. She doesn't think it has to. It's magic. It just is.

Chapter End Notes

The damage to the sword was *part* of why She-ra appeared as a magicat at first, although going back to my whole "She-ra is love" thing, part of the reason was also that Adora is gay for Catra. Light Hope also definitely wasn't entirely upfront with Adora about Multiple Things, including all the calculations and scenarios she ran.
By "special thing" Catra was just referring to Adora's protagonist syndrome.

Lovers

Chapter Notes

> Did you know that if you forget to close your HTML bracket AO3 eats the remainder of your comment? Now I do! I fixed/added to the ending note on the last chapter.
> This loosely follows the lore from my fic [the other half of you (exposure therapy).](#) where She-ra comes out sometimes when Adora feels a lot of love.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Seriously , why is She-ra a magicat sometimes?" Catra asks the morning after it all, when they are alone together in the shambles of Adora's old room in Bright Moon Castle. A lot of the furniture was toppled over, moved, or broken during the occupation, but most of the bedrooms still had a bed or at least something soft enough to lay on for a night. They slept on Adora's lounge for the night because her old cot was broken in half—and probably less comfortable, if she's honest. Fixing everything up will be a task for the next few days. They only just made their way back around sunset and there's a lot of work ahead of them.

"The sword was damaged over the last thousand years and it had a glitch," Adora responds, petting the top of Melog's head. They are sprawled on top of her lap while Catra pokes around the room. Adora is pretty sure that she is just rifling through Adora's things rather than assessing the damage. It isn't like Catra knows what anything should look like. She watches Catra straighten up and turn to send her a narrow-eyed look, her tail flicking aggressively behind her.

"The sword is gone," Catra returns, her tone suspicious. Adora feels like her face is warm. Catra has a point, but Adora still firmly believes that the sword *was* glitched before it broke completely.

"I know , but it showed me that She-ra can be whatever I need her to be," Adora explains, fixing her gaze down on Melog's ear as she carefully rubs it between her fingers, not wanting to pinch them. She does her best to not look up and meet Catra's skeptical gaze. It will only fluster her more and that will make it less believable. Catra didn't seem satisfied with "it's magic" before, but Adora thinks that is as close to an answer as they are going to get.

"What you *need* her to be? It's necessary to become a magicat?" Catra questions, incredulous. Adora's cheeks are flaming. Her entire body feels warm, almost like-

Warm light washes over the room. Melog flees from Adora's lap as she looks down at her hands to see her nails lengthening. When the transformation finishes, Adora's tail is already lashing behind her. Her ears are pinned back with embarrassment as she finally looks up to meet Catra's eyes. Catra's jaw is hanging open, her expression wide-eyed as Melog cautiously creeps back towards Adora, sniffing the air. Adora can feel her fur fluffing up a little, which is a new sensation to her, though she has watched it happen to Catra when she is flustered or scared before.

"Yeah, it was. I needed to become a magicat because I needed *you*. Sometimes I would wrap around my tail and pretend I was hugging you after we fought," she admits, quietly. She isn't ashamed to say it now, at least not to Catra, but she was ashamed of it for a very long time. Catra's tail is lashing as much as Adora's own as she gapes at her across the room. Adora reaches down, grabbing her still-lashing tail and pulling it forward into her lap so she has something to wrap her hands around. It's comforting.

"When I said in the heart that She-ra was a magicat because I love you, I think that's true too. At least now. I don't think I'll ever know for sure about before. But I always loved you, and looked up to you, and just thought you were so *cool* even before I understood anything else," Adora explains, still fidgeting. She and Catra always had their differences – once small, and then uncompromisingly large – but she still admired Catra too. She was strong in so many ways. She was

often underestimated and she tried to turn that into an advantage wherever she could, even if opportunities were few and far between. Adora had a lot of things handed to her, but Catra was *resourceful*.

Unfortunately, she didn't truly realize that last part until they had already parted ways. Adora knows she once brushed off some of Catra's struggles because she simply didn't experience them herself. If something was easy for her, it seemed like Catra of all people should be able to handle it, but Catra was almost always starting at a disadvantage, even if it wasn't obvious. Adora doesn't know if she would have been strong enough to be in Catra's place, but she doesn't know how Catra would have held up in hers either. They are very different people, used to living up to different standards.

"You- Really?" Catra starts, cutting off in a quiet whisper. Adora startles, looking up to find Catra's tail has wrapped around her, almost like she needs comfort. Adora fists her own tail and nods quickly.

"I missed you so much. I think being able to be a magicat myself was the only thing that kept me sane sometimes. I mean, it was fun and stuff too, but other times I really needed to just pretend," Adora admits, watching Catra's eyes sparkle until tears are threatening to spill over. She wants to run forward and hug her, but she doesn't know if Catra would want her to, or even allow it. She looks down towards Melog a bit desperately. Melog doesn't hesitate to run forward and headbutt into her lap, demanding immediate hugs in Catra's stead.

Adora curls around them, looking up to Catra and cautiously lifting a hand. If she weren't She-ra right now, she is sure it would tremble with nerves as she holds it out to Catra. Only a few feet stretch between them, but the distance was far less back at Thaymor and they never managed to cross that gap. Adora doesn't think the gathering tears are necessarily bad, but there are a *lot* of complicated feelings tangled between them. It almost seems impossible to unknot them without just cutting through with scissors and making things worse.

After a moment of labored breathing, Catra takes a single step forward. Adora's throat flexes and her fingers twitch hopefully, but Catra draws still again, staring down at Adora's hand with a war in her eyes. Adora doesn't know if that burning intensity is indicative of good or bad feelings, but they are certainly *strong*. Catra almost looks like she is locked in conflict. Adora's heartbeat seems to grow louder as the seconds stretch, the sound filling her sensitive ears.

Finally, Catra breaks, and this time she runs forward instead of away. Adora throws both her arms out and hauls Catra into her lap, squeezing her close as the dam breaks and Catra finally begins sobbing. She buries her face into Adora's shoulder as Melog nuzzles at her back to soothe her. Adora holds her close while doing her best not to squeeze her too tight. She thinks She-ra's size might be ideal for cuddles, but her strength is less so. Still, Adora is pretty sure that they are going to make enough attempts at this for her to get used to moderating it. It feels like a dam bursts inside her the moment Catra finally crawls into her lap, and after a few seconds she is crying too.

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Catra cries a bit in between sketching out a picture for Adora, rough and clearly missing details, of just how much hatred She-ra made her feel during the war, especially towards herself. Adora murmurs assurances and refutes every one of Catra's misguided beliefs, but after awhile Catra growls.

"*Stop.* It doesn't matter what you say that you felt now, back then I *knew* you hated me. And I hurt everyone I could, myself included, because of it," she snaps, raising her head to glare at Adora. Adora draws in a sharp breath, taken aback by Catra's tear-stained face so close to her own. Her ears are pinned back, her tail lashing behind her. Melog doesn't seem to have shifted colors, but it's hard to tell when She-ra is partially colorblind like all magicats.

Catra looks strung out and pained, her glare turning into a much more heartbreaking expression of regret as she seems to process the stricken look on Adora's face. Melog nuzzles against Catra from where they are draped around them, trying to comfort her. That's what Adora wanted to do too, trying to assure her that she never felt that way about her. She thinks it was working at first, but clearly she has pushed Catra too far.

After what Catra has admitted this morning, Adora knows more than ever that she needs to be patient with her. Adora isn't great at waiting, but she doesn't think anything except time is going to help Catra realize that she was always loved. Clearly Catra is feeling talked down too – and clearly that has been a bigger issue between them than Adora ever knew – but as much as Adora needs to stop doing that, she also wants Catra to know that she was never her intention.

"Okay," she says, her voice soft as she reaches up and cautiously cups the back of Catra's head. She half expects Catra to hiss and pull away, but her ears have gone limp now and she lets Adora guide her back into the tight, intertwined ball they had curled themselves into with Melog curled around the outside. Adora didn't think it was possible, but she manages to tuck her tail in even more around Catra.

"I'm sorry. I wanted to assure you that I always loved you, not make it seem like you were wrong and I was right. I'm not really any better at emotions than you are," Adora tells her, pressing a kiss to one of Catra's drooping ears. Catra nuzzles against her neck in response, rubbing her face – and earlier tears – there. Adora always thought this was a comfort-seeking gesture when they were kids, but she has done it herself now and she knows there is more to it than just comfort. It's deeper, seeking and expressing affection. In this moment, it might very well be an apology too, but it is at least a communication of the same affection back.

"I'm right here," Adora breathes to her, watching Catra's ears twitch as her breath puffs over them. Catra sniffles against her, burying her

face in against her shoulder and holding it there for a long moment. Adora doesn't really think she is going to say anything more. There is definitely more to talk about, but they've done enough for now. It's apparent that Catra has pushed herself as far as she can today and then Adora pushed her a little more.

"Purr for me?" Catra asks in a low whisper, surprising Adora. She sounds conflicted, or at the very least strained. Adora's tail lashes to the other side and thuds against the back of the couch. Back in the Horde, Catra would have stayed defensive and run away after something like this, leaving Adora to hunt her down later after she had cooled off. Now she just *asks* for comfort. Adora is more than happy to provide it. She buries her face in Catra's mane, taking a few long seconds to stutter out some growly sounds that make Catra snort before Adora manages to get a proper purr going again. Catra, to her surprise, joins her after a few seconds.

It isn't a jubilant purr, but Adora knows by now that not all of them are. Almost all of her own purrs have been to soothe. Catra needs this right now. Maybe she couldn't manage one on her own and needed Adora to kick it off, or maybe she just wanted to feel what it was like when someone else did it for her. It's a new sensation for them both to have their purrs mingling. This isn't how Adora pictured them cuddling and purring together, but she holds Catra tightly and does her best to assure her physically since her words failed.

It took a lot for Catra to talk about her feelings and she needs time before she will be recovered from this crying session. They're probably going to have to leave the room soon and face what rebuilding from a war looks like, so Adora needs to do everything that she can to comfort her before that.

Actually, fuck that. If someone comes looking for them, Adora is going to hiss at them to go away until Catra is ready to go on her own. Catra needs time to heal.

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No one disturbs them before Catra works through her emotions and then gets predictably defensive, curling in on herself and insisting the others are going to bother them soon if they dont head out. Adora almost breaks her rule of giving Catra time right away, but she obeys when Catra tells her to drop the transformation as soon as they pull away from each other. She worries that Catra didnt want to see She-ra anymore.

That worry is exacerbated when it turns out that She-ra is actually needed just an hour later when a few confused clones cut of f from the hivemind come wondering into Bright Moon, but Catra seems at worst confused when she sees Adora walking around as She-ra afterwards. She missed the tense stand-off while helping with rebuilding on the other end of the castle, mostly because it was over so fast. Wrong Horde was surprisingly helpful in convincing the clones to stand down and within half an hour Entrapta has somehow talked them into helping with the clean up.

"Human again, huh?" Catra asks afterwards, eyeing her with a light in her eye that has always made Adora stand at attention. During the war she thought of it was predatory and her response to it was the natural preparation to defend herself, but now Adora cant help but feel like there is an appreciation there mixing with Catra's curiosity. Either way, it makes her blush as she reaches up to absently run her hand over her long ponytail.

"I think it depends on why Im transforming. Maybe. I didnt *choose* to be human, but it feels right, to be myself for stuf f like this," she responds, shrugging. Magicat She-ra doesnt *not* feel like her, but it certainly isnt the same as wearing her own skin, even if sometimes she might prefer the magicat form. Catra raises an eyebrow at her, sending Adora a look like she doesnt quite believe her before she turns away to get back to work. Adora lets out a breath, a bit relieved that Catra isnt picking around for a better answer . She still doesnt

have one except that the magicat form isn't for fighting anymore, at least not in her mind.

Catra doesn't say anything more about it, but Adora catches her watching her haul furniture around later. She thinks the look is appreciative – she hopes so, anyway – but Catra immediately pretends to be busy when she realizes Adora has spotted her, so it's hard to be sure. Adora stays as She-ra for a good chunk of the day though, helping put the castle back together and trying to comfort the civilians starting to make their way back to Bright Moon with her presence. She-ra is a powerful guard dog and maybe an even more powerful symbol, and though she looks different now, she is still recognizable.

Rebuilding is a lot of work and going to continue to be, but seeing Catra somehow manage to interact with the rest of the Alliance without getting too defensive or aggressive even after their emotional morning assures Adora that they have a bright future to look forward to.

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Adora can control it. Kind of. She doesn't have choosing She-ra's form on lock, but apparently Catra can just *make her turn into She-ra* whenever she does something that makes Adora feel too much, so she doesn't have tight control over anything right now. If Catra triggers the transformation, though, it ends up being magicat She-ra. Catra seems a bit conflicted by it. Her eyes usually dilate, and sometimes she seems amused too, but all three of the times that she triggers magicat She-ra to show up in the next few days, she quickly tells Adora to change back.

Adora wants to ask, but she also doesn't want to push. They have a lot of other stuff they end up talking about in the mean time that is

important too, and Catra's feelings about Adora's magical racial transformation take a back burner after the initial conversation. Whenever She-ra is actually needed for something, it's her human form that appears, and Catra never seems to mind that, often pretending to – or just plain openly – ogling her as she works.

After Catra triggers Adora transforming for a fourth time, she doesn't even have to ask for Adora to turn back. After a moment of blazing embarrassment, Adora forces down the swell of emotions in her chest and manages to revert as Glimmer laughs at her in the background. Her friends find it endlessly amusing that She-ra is still a magicat when Catra is involved. None of them seem to believe that She-ra was a magicat initially because of a glitch in the sword anymore. Well, none of them except Entrapta, who actually believes in *facts* and remembers that Light Hope found errors in the sword's code.

When they get back to Adora's room that night, Adora is surprised by Catra turning around almost the instant they are in the door and fixing her with a burning look. Adora blinks back, glancing between Catra's firm expression and Melog. Melog doesn't seem at all tense, ignoring them both in favor of hopping up into the bed that replaced Adora's old cot. Both Catra and Melog love the comfort of the plush beds that are standard in Bright Moon, but Adora is sure that if something bad was going on with Catra, they would resist its siren call to stay close and comfort her.

"Catra?" Adora questions, making eye contact again. Catra is almost frowning at her, staring intensely. Adora would ask if she has something on her, but if that were the case then Catra would have just laughed at her without explaining why and left it up to someone else to inform her, preferably after Catra had her fun. Catra's gaze darts away, some of the intensity fading from her eyes by the time she makes eye contact with Adora again.

"Turn into She-ra," she orders, an edge of caution to her voice. Adora blinks at her, surprised. Given Catra's obviously conflicted feelings about She-ra, it isn't something that Adora really expected

Catra to ask. Sure, she always dreamed of them curling up as magicats together, but she has accepted – or at least is trying to – that she has to put those dreams on hold for now. As excited as she is at the possibility that Catra wants that, she hesitates.

"Which?" she asks. Catra quirks her brow at her, flicking her tail behind her.

"You can choose?" she questions, sounding a bit amused. Adora huffs, screwing her face up a little at Catra. She knows that she has only been a magicat recently when she transformed "on accident," but it was a valid question as much as she wants to be indignant about it.

"I wouldn't say that, but I think I can influence it," Adora explains. She hasn't necessarily *tried* to summon one form over the other, but given how her transformations have been working out, she thinks she can. Hopefully. Catra looks a bit skeptical, but mostly amused, at least for the few moments before she seems to remember the conversation they're having and her expression gains that hesitance again.

"Magicat She-ra," she admits, begrudgingly. Adora can't help the way she perks up. It must be obvious because Catra's tail immediately lashes from side-to-side and her cheeks flush. Catra huffs as her ears pin back. Adora shouldn't push, but she isn't known for her restraint.

"You want to cuddle?" she asks, a bit of excitement mixing with the teasing tone in her voice. It's pretty much the only reason Adora can picture Catra "putting up with" She-ra's magicat form in private. She did admit back on Darla that it was something she thought about even when they were fighting. Catra's ears pin back even tighter and she gives a low hiss, but Adora knows what Catra sounds like when she is actually angry and that isn't it. She is, at most, flustered and defensive. Catra's tail lashes as she glares firmly at Adora's shoulder.

"I don't know," she admits, practically through gritted teeth. Adora's breath skips for a moment. Not knowing is a weakness and an opportunity for someone to use it against you. Catra is *trying* though, and even if she hadn't asked for it, Adora now feels the glow in her heart that always proceeds She-ra making an unplanned appearance. She offers Catra an encouraging smile, watching a little of her defensiveness ease even as the gentle glow of She-ra's magic becomes visible reflected back in Catra's eyes.

Adora closes her eyes and breathes out slowly, focusing on thoughts of Catra as the transformation takes her. When she opens her eyes, her tail is already swaying hopefully. Catra's ears are still twitched back and she looks no less hesitant than she did before. Her eyes dart all over Adora, taking in various details, but Adora notices that her gaze especially sticks on Adora's tails and ears. She wonders if she is cataloguing Adora's body language and if she is better at reading Adora than Adora is at reading her. Catra has a lot more years of experience in what reactions her own emotions cause, but she also has never needed to read the emotions of a magicat before. Adora has spent her entire life doing it.

"I hated her for so long. When She-ra actually looks like you, it's easy. It's *you*. But I... I need to ease into *this*," Catra says, gesturing vaguely towards Adora as she finishes. Adora's tail movement slows and she nods. That isn't a surprise – Adora has been paying attention to Catra's reactions ever since their first talk about She-ra – but it is a relief to hear it. Despite how alert Catra is and her conflicted emotions, she is pushing herself into a position to confront it. Adora offers Catra her best encouraging smile, trying to hold still and prove to Catra that she can hold back to let Catra do this at her own pace.

After a second of shooting Adora a cautious look, Catra seems to accept that Adora isn't going to scoop her up for a hug and returns to just watching her. Adora busies herself with trying to observe Catra's body language. Her eyes are sweeping over Adora, occasionally lingering and occasionally darting around, but her expression is

impassive. Her ears are slowly returning to their normal position again, facing forward. Despite her ears relaxing, her tail doesn't do the same. It is still just like it was when Adora first opened her eyes, but it is a tense stillness.

Slowly, as Catra seems to just stand and watch, her tail relaxes a little. The tip starts flicking occasionally. Adora thinks it's a good flick, excited or maybe curious, but it's hard to tell with the tension still slipping out of Catra's body. Adora resists the urge to bounce on her toes or say something. She has to let Catra take her time, but standing still and waiting is *hard*. She can't hide her emotions despite her overall stillness though because her tail is starting to lash behind her.

Catra takes a step forward, causing Adora's tail to still and her ears to prick forward. Catra glances up to send her an amused look, but she looks away when Adora quickly grins at her. Adora is just relieved that Catra is less tense. Catra approaches slowly, stopping just in front of her. Adora holds her breath for a long moment, waiting, as Catra just stands there. An eternity passes, and then Catra unexpectedly leans forward, butting her head against Adora's pecs. All of Adora's breath leaves her, but before she can suck in another one, Catra has turned her cheeks and is rubbing a long scent mark all the way to her bicep.

If Adora weren't already She-ra, she would definitely surface now. Her tail lashes from side to side with excitement as Catra lifts her head to place it at a better angle to rub against her arm. As she marks her, she begins to purr softly. Adora doesn't intentionally purr as well, but she's *excited*. It feels amazing to have Catra rubbing up against her, and it's even more exciting when Adora is a magicat too and can actually detect the scent marks Catra is leaving behind. She has marked her many times, but not while Adora was She-ra.

Catra doesn't stop at a mark or two. She practically wraps around Adora, nuzzling and marking her as she goes, even throwing in an occasional lick or two against her fur. The entire time, she purrs like engine. Adora purrs too, unable to move but having to express her

happiness *somehow*. Well, her lashing tail gives away her excitement, but it's not enough when she almost feels like she is floating. She has dreamed of them doing something like this for so long. When they were this close before, there were too many tense emotions pulling them down. Now, Adora feels lighter than air.

Catra must be somewhat satisfied with her marks now, because she tucks herself against Adora's side and buries her face against her. It takes everything in Adora to not scoop Catra up and carry her to the bed so they can properly cuddle. If this is the way Catra is comfortable doing it right now, then Adora will happily oblige. As much as it is killing her to be still and not participate too, even this feels incredible. Against her chest, Catra feels oddly small. She has seemed small compared to She-ra a few times before, but never quite like this.

Adora just wants to pick her up and take care of her. Catra would probably take her arm off if she tried. She doesn't need caring for and all that. Being tough doesn't mean she doesn't need love too, though, and Adora hopes that Catra is starting to realize that. Cautiously, Adora twitches her arm a little to *almost* be curling around Catra's side, but just subtly enough that she can deny it if she wants to. She doesn't want to push Catra too much. Behind her, Catra's tail flicks along with one ear tip. Adora hopes it is amusement and not annoyance, but it isn't clear with Catra's face partially hidden.

"Can you keep yourself from marking me?" Catra asks, her tone teasing as she turns her head to peer up at Adora with one gold eye. Adora swears she gets heart palpitations just seeing Catra's face again, but she manages to nod quickly.

"Definitely," she says with confidence that may very well be false. Adora actually really wants to leave scent marks on Catra, but she wants to respect her boundaries. She can probably just scent mark the bed like she used to if it gets to be too much. She just wants Catra in her arms. Catra seems amused—and maybe a bit

disbelieving, but she pulls back with a smile on her face and takes Adora's hand. Breathlessly, Adora lets herself be led to the bed.

Melog flees as they approach, giving a small mew as they slink away and climb up on the couch that Catra and Adora shared on the first night. Adora is surprised given that they have slept with them ever since they found a bed big enough for it, but apparently Melog being cuddly themselves doesnt mean they are happy participating in a three-way cuddle. Any concerns about them go out the window when Adora sits down and Catra climbs into her lap, however.

Catra encourages her to lay back with a gentle hand on her shoulder. After a moment of rearranging, they both end up stretched out in the bed, Catra on top of Adora. Catra cuddles up to her chest, seeming to do her level best to plaster herself against Adora until their bodies magically melt together and become one.

"Purr ," Catra orders, her voice quiet but firm. Adora blinks up at the ceiling for a moment, confused, before she realizes that they both stopped purring at some point during the location move. Cautiously, she lifts one arm to drape over Catra's back, cuddling her tight against her chest – though it isnt like she can get much closer – as she begins to purr. Already near bliss, she doesnt need any growly false starts to get the vibration going in her chest. Catra begins to purr as well, melting down onto her chest.

Adora's eyes fall hooded without her intending it. With Catra plastered so close against her, she cant really see anything but her ears anyway. Adora lets her eyes fall all the way closed. She doesnt need sight, after all. Happiness leaks from them both in the form of a buzzy purr and content scents mingling together . Cautiously, Adora lifts another arm to wrap around Catra in a proper hug. Catra purrs harder, if possible. Adora takes it as permission and happily curls around Catra in return, wrapping her tail over her as she cuddles her.

Catra loves it. She doesnt have to say anything for Adora to know that. Catra clings to her even tighter and reeks of contentment. Adora thinks that scent might be a drug. She hasnt gotten to soak in

Catra's happy endorphins before and she swears they make her body relax in turn. She desperately wants to nuzzle against her, but she doesn't think she could avoid marking Catra then and she made Catra a promise. It feels so good to be cuddled together, but it's almost like all the good emotions pouring into her are about to overflow.

Adora turns her head and rubs her cheek against the pillow somewhat aggressively. Their bed is covered in Catra's scent marks by now, though Adora hasn't been in the room as a magicat since that first day, so this is her first time smelling them even if she watched Catra leave a number of them. It feels so good to be in a space surrounded in her and Catra's scents. Is this how Catra felt in their old bunk in the Horde?

Well, definitely not, because they have a freedom and a *love* here that they never could have had back then, but Adora understands why Catra's instinct was to curl up in the bunk and turn into a ball whenever she was sick or injured now. This is heaven and Adora is too far gone to care about how aggressively she is marking the pillow, intent on mixing her scent with Catra's as well as relieve the instinct inside her. Against her chest, Catra's purr grows buzzy.

"What, too much for you?" Catra chuckles, lifting her head up just enough to watch with amusement. Adora responds by whining and turning over on her side so she can wrap more tightly around Catra. Catra's eyes grow wide, but she trills as Adora repositions them, and once they stop moving both of them melt into the embrace. The new position also means Adora can more easily nuzzle the pillow to deal.

"I love you. So much. So much it's stupid," Adora babbles out, displaying the *stupid* part quite well. Catra trills again, her eyes blown out and her tail thudding over Adora's. It makes noise only where its tip manages to hit the bed, otherwise too cushioned by Adora's fluff. Adora drinks in the expression of open affection and wonder. Alright, she wishes Catra looked less surprised, but she loves getting to tell her how she feels after all these years, and she loves seeing the *happiness* on her face in response.

Even with the rules and having to hold herself back from scent marking, this is probably the best night of her life.

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They stay wrapped together for a while. They dont talk for the most part, too busy cuddling and purring. Eventually Adora manages to calm down. She is finally able to nuzzle against Catra' s hair without worrying about marking her against her wishes. Catra purrs along with her as she does it, sighing happily when Adora settles her head back on the pillow.

"I like this," Catra whispers like it is some dirty secret. Adora' s tail immediately lashes over their legs with excitement. Catra snickers a little as she ducks to rub another scent mark underneath Adora's jaw.

"Yeah?" Adora responds, unable to hide the hopefulness in her voice. Her tail already gave away her excitement, but if Catra decides she likes this then they might be able to do it again soon. She loves this and she really wants Catra to love it too. Catra's tail thuds once against the bed as she settles tucked in against her neck.

"Yeah. Dont start thinking we're going to do this every night though," Catra warns, but her tone is still amused. Adora purrs a little as she nuzzles into her hair again. She doesnt just want to do this every night, she wants to do it for the rest of her life.

"We could," she murmurs into Catra' s hair. It isnt a serious suggestion, but she's just so happy for them to finally be able to cuddle like this without the tension of the war between them. Catra pauses in the middle of rubbing a scent mark on the side of Adora's neck. Adora's tail immediately stills, waiting for Catra's response.

Catra huffs. Adora feels the tip of her tail flicking back and forth against her knee.

"I couldn't," Catra whispers back. Her voice is too low for Adora to pick up any emotion, whether calm or stressed, from it. All she has to go on is Catra's stillness and a small flick of her ear. Adora ducks her head and presses a soft kiss there. Adora noticed just yesterday that Catra has trained her – unconsciously or purposefully – to kiss her ears when she flicks them close to Adora's face. She hopes Catra finds it soothing.

"Okay . Whenever you want. I love this, but I love you more. I want you to be comfortable," Adora assures her . Catra immediately trills, her tail lashing behind her as she buries her face in Adora's shoulder like she is trying to suffocate herself there. Adora grins to herself, turning her head to follow Catra and kiss her ear again. This time she adds a cautious lick as well. She has seen Catra lick to soothe herself many times and even been on the receiving end of it back in the Horde. Adora tried it on herself during the war , but this is her first time trying it on someone else.

It feels kind of awkward to do – maybe because Adora also tried this once when they were kids and Catra dodged away shrieking with laughter – but Catra rumbles softly against her neck, so she doesn't seem to mind. Adora nuzzles against the top of her head, still trying to assure her. After a few moments of flustered hiding, Catra feels oddly hesitant, still buried in Adora's neck. Adora can't name why it feels different than before. Maybe it's just the extra senses afforded to her as a magicat.

"We can do it when you want too. Not always, but you can ask," Catra finally whispers against her neck, shocking Adora. Adora's tail instantly thuds against the bed. Despite Catra's obvious hesitance, she manages to chuckle a little as Adora squeezes her close. As soon as she feels like she can almost breath again, she eases off, not wanting to crush Catra or make her feel trapped.

"Ok. I'd like that," Adora whispers back. It's such progress from Catra that she almost feels breathless. Adora has been optimistic ever since Catra first promised to her that she would try, and especially ever since the heart, but for the first time Adora just knows in her heart that they are going to be okay. This is her old Catra back – as much as she still exists – offering Adora the same comfort that she tries to provide her. Sure, they are different people now, but maybe they can be *better* people, at least when it comes to their relationship with each other.

Adora curls around Catra, feeling too much to process and certainly too much for words, but relief and happiness mix in her veins as she cuddles her close. However hard repairing their relationship is going to be, they're going to do it. They're going to be there for each other and find middle ground wherever they have to. They're going to be *happy*.

Chapter End Notes

Yes I changed the chapter count again. Ill be back with "Catra's Epilogue" soon.

Catra's Epilogue

Chapter Notes

I wasn't even going to finish this today, nor was I planning for it to be so long, but I needed a distraction. It was all written and edited at once, so I make no promises.
Light allusions to sex(ish) stuff in this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

If Catra's feelings about She-ra seemed complicated before, they get impossibly more tangled after Adora rescues her from Prime. Catra doesn't even know about She-ra's new form at first – she was kind of *half-dead* when she first appeared – but once she sees her, it's a bit of a relief.

And a bit of a disappointment. Like she said, *complicated*. A world recovering from war is ripe with excuses to not confront her feelings, but Catra can't push off dealing with them forever since She-ra just keeps *showing up* when Adora looks at her too hard or something.

Catra likes magicat She-ra. She hates her. She's a symbol of Adora's love for her. She's Adora trying to replace Catra in every way. Feelings from before left strong impressions and still linger in the back of her mind even as Catra allows Adora to scoop her up in She-ra's human form and scatter kisses along her cheek at the end of a long day of rebuilding. Human She-ra is easy to deal with – if Catra's honest, she kind of has the hots for her – but it takes longer for her to ease into approaching her magicat form.

Once she does though, she finds that she loves spending time with Adora like that. It isn't something she can handle on the days when her self-doubt is at its worst, but it feels like she and Adora can be closer than ever before. Catra even finds herself turning to it as a source of comfort some days, the two of them wrapping together and Adora purring as Catra kneads along her side.

She still needs her rules – Adora can't surprise her with it, or scent mark her – but with those in place, Catra finds herself crawling into She-ra's arms for comfort. A few years ago, she would have hated herself should she have received a vision of this future. Now, she sinks into Adora's embrace.

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Adora isn't allowed to scent mark her because Catra is still cagey about She-ra. It eases her to mark She-ra as her own and have Adora hold back. Adora isn't trying to own her , replace her, *leave* her. No, Adora is hers and She-ra is too. Maybe the most powerful being in the universe and Adora brings her out at a moment's notice if Catra requests her . Of course, Adora is always happy to be a magicat for her own reasons, but she holds She-ra back for Catra too.

Catra can't help but tease her about how much Adora likes being a magicat. Catra is a little conflicted about that too, but much less so. It's mostly amusing to watch Adora wriggling in the sheets, her tail lashing as she runs a hand through the fluff on her own stomach. Catra quickly bats her hand aside and replaces it with her own, sinking it into the softness blanketing hard muscles beneath it. Adora grins down at her as Catra stretches out beside Adora so she can sink into the luxurious mattress.

Catra begins kneading against Adora, purring as Adora relaxes beneath her. The benefit of She-ra is that Adora barely feels Catra's claws. She can dig her claws in without fear of hurting her. She has made She-ra bleed in battle of course, but that is far from the level of force she uses when she kneads. She settles with her eyes hooded, gazing up at Adora as she begins kneading too, working the soft mattress with her hands at her sides. Catra still can't get over Bright Moon beds or the fact that Adora *chose* not to use one for years, but

Catra has been teaching her how to be a magicat in bits and pieces and that means appreciating comfort.

Melog is draped over Adora's feet, doing their part to keep She-ra in place for Catra. It's one of those quiet moments where Catra feels so divorced from the angry, heartbroken girl who only knew how to lash out that she struggles to believe that happened in this life. She knows very well that she could wake up feeling pained and scared all over again, but it is at least a comfort to know it's a flashback and not her present. Besides, when that happens Adora will either bring She-ra out for her or hold her back. They will be able to handle it. Catra is too comfortable right now to worry about a potential bad day in the future.

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Catra likes human She-ra. A lot. Look, can you blame her? It's her girlfriend but even more jacked and a *goddess*. Sure, she isn't as good for cuddling as Adora's magicat form, but she also doesn't have her baggage. Catra doesn't – usually – think dirty thoughts about magicat She-ra, but her human form? Catra *thinks* about her human form the same way that she thinks about Adora. That's the real gap: these days, She-ra is just Adora. Magicat She-ra isn't. She never was, even if Adora enjoys being a magicat and it's kind of heartwarming to watch Adora enjoy being a little more like Catra.

"Are you going to start drooling?" Glimmer whispers in Catra's ear, an infuriating smirk on her face when Catra turns to half-heartedly swipe at her. Glimmer – completely unnecessarily – teleports back a few feet, laughing. Catra has no problem unabashedly staring at Adora whenever she feels like it, but it has become a source of jokes. Catra is more likely to stop if Adora catches her than if their friends tease her – she doesn't need to inflate Adora's ego or ruin

what is left of her brooding persona – so she responds by turning towards Adora as Glimmer snickers behind her.

"Hey, Adora," Catra calls out, doing her best to purr the words despite the volume she has to speak them for Adora to hear her down the hill where she is hauling supplies to help rebuild war damage. Adora immediately looks up, whipping her head around to spot Catra and grinning broadly when she sees her. Adora raises her arm, waving back at Catra. Catra's response to that is raising her right hand to her mouth and making a lewd gesture.

Adora fumbles the beam she is carrying, barely managing to catch it in time. She turns bright red as Glimmer shrieks with laughter.

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Catra had never touched another magicat before Adora found the sword. As much hatred as She-ra once made her feel, sometimes it feels monumental to run her hands through Adora's fur and smell her scent marks on the bed they share. It is a constant territory war when it comes to marks on their mattress, mostly because Adora *needs* to mark something and Catra is a competitive little shit. Adora isn't any less of a gremlin, frequently marking Melog when they try to nuzzle her while making pointed eye contact with Catra.

Melog purrs, just like they do every time, the traitor. It seems to amuse Adora, emboldening her to crawl on top of Catra and grin down at her. Both of their tails are lashing as Catra glares back up at Adora. Adora doesn't seem at all deterred, chuckling a little as she drops down to nuzzle under Catra's jaw and press a kiss there. Catra tilts her head back with faux reluctance. At the end of the bed, Melog batts playfully at Adora's tail as Adora kisses a line down Catra's throat. The kisses are soft and gentle, but neck kisses are kind of a *thing* for magicats and Catra shivers anyway.

She glares at Adora for real when Adora pulls back and grins down at her, far too smug at Catra's annoyance. Catra wants to demand why she stopped, but that would mean admitting that she wanted Adora to start in the first place and they both know Catra isn't going to do that. She can say nothing while maintaining her aloof façade. Not that it isn't already a little ruined since she asked Adora to transform and that's basically code for *let's cuddle*, but she can pretend.

"You looked like you were getting jealous," Adora smirks. Catra glares at her, huffing as Melog takes a swipe at *her* tail now. They are bored watching Adora and Catra cuddle, but they also get secondhand endorphins from it, so they don't want to wander off and explore the castle just yet. The further apart they are, the weaker the bond is. Catra doesn't know if they could ever be far enough apart to not feel each other at all now they have bonded, but *feelings* get watered down when they're apart.

They aren't apart now and Catra felt the contentment from Melog when Adora marked them. They don't mind the marks at all. They know Catra wouldn't either if it weren't for her weird hang-ups, but they are getting better. Truthfully, Catra uses Melog to lay claim over Adora far more than Adora's marks on them do the reverse. Melog will crawl into Adora's lap when Catra can't, follow her around to keep an eye on her, and even admonish her with loud mews on Catra's behalf when they find her overworking herself. Melog is an extension of Catra as much as they are their own being, and that distance but *closeness* is what allows Catra to feel so much – and have it be positive – when Adora marks them.

The problem is that Adora was right: Catra is a little jealous. Adora likes leaving scent marks when she is a magicat, and she especially likes smelling Catra's own, but most of the time she can't pick them up, so they aren't a huge deal to her. Catra can always smell them. Scents surround her the same way the rainbow paints most people's vision. If Adora marks her, that scent will be on her all day. There

might be traces of it until she next showers. It isn't a fleeting moment for her.

A few weeks ago, it might have panicked her. Right now, she doesn't feel that doubt. Truthfully, she hasn't for a while, but she has still held back for fear of waking up on a bad day with the scent still lingering and feeling like Adora is once again trying to take over what little she has. She doesn't know if it is really possible to feel like that anymore though, because what she has isn't so *little*. She has Adora. She has Melog. She has *friends* – princess friends, even – that she actually trusts. She is an advisor to the queen of Bright Moon with real power that isn't simply fear-based. For the first time in her life, there isn't a figure leaning over her that she fears will pounce on her the moment she slips up.

Adora never wanted to replace her before and she doesn't want to now. She isn't trying to take anything from Catra. Catra isn't proving anything by keeping Adora's marks off her. She kind of wants them. She wants to smell Adora on her throughout the day, affection lingering on her fur. She has been perfectly happy with the natural traces that Adora leaves behind in every form, but this would be stronger and much more intentional. Now, she doesn't worry about it like she once did. She just wants to relax in Adora's arms.

"They were being smug," Catra huffs at Adora. It's true, but Adora doesn't look any less smug than Melog is. Melog bats at her tail again before hopping down from the bed to go wandering. They're bored, but they are also giving Catra time with Adora. She could kind of use moral support right now, but Melog thinks that moral support should be Adora. Catra sends a glare their way as they nudge the door to their bedroom open so they can leave. Melog is supposed to take her side, not force her to do what is *healthy* or whatever.

Unfortunately, they do that often. Like Catra said, they're a traitor. When she looks back to Adora, she seems amused, but also a bit confused watching Melog leave. She sends Catra a questioning look that makes her blush. Catra can admit that there usually is a *pattern* to when Melog leaves and it's often when Catra wants to make out,

something they've never done with Adora in this form. Human She-ra, yes, *multiple* times, but usually they just cuddle when Adora is like this.

"They're bored," Catra offers, because it's true, even if there is more to it than that. Adora raises a brow at her, but she seems hesitant to tease her about this. Just a few weeks ago, Catra wouldn't have wanted to even have She-ra braced above her like this. They're making progress – alright, Catra is making progress and Adora is being patient with her – but Adora has been trying not to push her. That is the progress Adora is making, actually. She is learning to give Catra room and how to talk to her. Catra is learning to talk at all.

Sometimes progress is monumental, sometimes it is slow and reluctant, but it's still *happening*. Catra raises her arms to hook them around Adora's shoulders and pull her down into a kiss. Adora draws in a quick breath through her nose, giving a muffled noise of surprise despite how gently Catra pulled her in. Catra rumbles with amusement as Adora finally gets with the program and kisses her back. This isn't the very first time they have kissed with Adora in this form, but Catra can count the number of times they have done it on one hand. They kiss each other on the cheek like this more often than they truly *kiss*.

Adora doesn't seem at all disappointed to do it now, though, settling against Catra happily. Kissing Adora as She-ra is always different – she's bigger, after all – but Catra doesn't really mind the taste of magic. It's different all over again when she is a magicat. The same differences human She-ra has are there, but now her cheeks are fuzzy and her tongue is textured. Catra supposes this must be what it is like for Adora to kiss her, she just never thought about what it is like for Adora until she experienced it herself.

It's different, but the happy hum Adora makes as she kisses her with an open mouth isn't. Catra pulls back to breathe, smiling to herself when Adora nuzzles her cheek, apparently unable to stand breaking contact for too long. Catra purrs, nuzzling back. After all the internal debate, she doesn't even think twice about the action in the moment,

just rubbing their cheeks together because she wants to. Catra has been growing comfortable giving into her instincts since coming to Bright Moon, but ones like this she has been continually holding back.

Adora doesn't seem to realize anything at first, just purring in response. The world doesn't shatter with their cheeks rubbing together and Catra just wants to keep going. She inclines her head, rubbing her temple against Adora now. By the time she has worked her way to the base of her ear, Adora seems to realize that Catra is marking herself with her scent. Adora draws in a sharp breath and Catra purrs, dropping her head back against the pillow. She finds Adora looking down at her with wide, shining eyes.

"Well, do I have to do it all myself?" Catra asks, her tail thumping against the bed. She is being obtuse, but if Adora had a problem with that, they wouldn't be dating. Adora continues to stare down at her, her expression unshifting. She seems to be in shock. Catra huffs, but she isn't annoyed. Truthfully, she is smiling. Apparently the answer is *yes*. Catra butts her head forward, rubbing it up against Adora's cheek as gently as she can. Not that she thinks an affectionate headbutt is going to hurt She-ra, but Adora seems to be having a moment. After a few seconds, Adora cautiously rubs back. Catra sighs, letting her head drop again. Adora's expression is wonderous.

"Can I?" she asks, sounding disbelieving. Catra snorts, her tail sweeping back and forth on the mattress. Adora's is lashing.

"Yeah, you can. I want to smell like you. At least right now," Catra admits. She's a bit reluctant to say it, but the loving look in Adora's eyes spurs her forward. Adora swallows, her ears practically quivering with excitement as she quickly nods.

"I'll ask first," she promises. Catra suppresses a light shiver, though her eyes still fall closed for a moment. When she opens them, Adora still looks equally touched and excited, but she finally leans forward and rubs her cheek against Catra's jaw. Catra feels a deep-rooted

contentment whenever she marks Adora and she would guess Adora feels the same given the way her purr revs up as she nuzzles against Catra.

Catra didn't expect receiving the marks to feel so *good*. She worried that it would feel like Adora was trying to take come kind of control from her, but instead it just feels like Adora is speaking her language. Probably because she *is*. This is just how magicats express affection. Though Adora tells Catra she loves her often and Catra can even smell and feel affection from her on a daily basis, it is different than the deep-seated understanding of an action that she is biologically hard-wired to understand.

Catra is purring as loud as Adora now as Adora, apparently trying to make up for lost time, rubs all along the side of Catra's head and even makes her way down to her neck. Catra closes her eyes, deciding maybe it isn't the time to overthink and dissect this emotion. As much distress as She-ra being a magicat once caused her, Catra is so grateful to have someone who speaks her language. Adora always understood her better than anyone else, but now she can actually speak back, and that is a relief that Catra never thought she would get before.

When Adora grows close enough, Catra lightly kisses her ears or her cheek, but mostly she lays back and lets Adora rub against her. Both their purrs fill the air. Catra feels boneless, melting beneath the warmth of Adora's affection. Sure, Adora is marking Catra as hers, but it isn't about possession or taking anything from her. No, Adora *wants* her and she doesn't want anyone else to take Catra away. The marks are as loving as they are territorial, just like they are when Catra leaves them herself.

She doesn't know why she feared it would be different. This is Adora, after all. She might as well be made of love. Giving too much of it away has kind of been a consistent problem for her, but this is just for Catra, a part of Adora she is certain she never has and never would offer to someone else. Catra didn't think it was possible to purr harder than she already was, but that thought does it.

This definitely isnt the last time they are doing this. Catra will happily throw away all the traces of old, imagined betrayals if she gets to have something like this.

Chapter End Notes

> Is there anything cuter than when a cat gets so happy it starts headrubbing everything?
> This might be my last fic for a bit as I focus on personal projects again, but I do have another fic idea that Ive written a bit for also, so I guess the schedule is: who the fuck knows ¯_(ツ)_/¯

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